

Chapter 71 Part 1

Before returning to the company, Xu Qingzhu went to the coffee shop downstairs to buy a cup of coffee.

When she was about to pay with her phone, she discovered a message from Zhou Yi'an. She paid first.

Just as the staff handed her the coffee, she tapped the screen with one hand to read the message. When she saw the sentence on the screen, her hand trembled and the coffee nearly spilled.

"Careful!" The staff member urgently called out, reaching over the counter to help steady it.

Xu Qingzhu came back to her senses and hastily thanked them.

No matter how much turmoil was churning in her heart, she maintained a calm and composed expression on her face. She closed her phone and entered the company with her coffee.

As a result, she ran into Zhou Yi'an again at the elevator entrance downstairs.

People who had just finished eating lunch outside were crowding back into the company, making the elevator entrance somewhat congested.

Yet Zhou Yi'an seemed to have a special ability to make crowds stay away from her.

She stood alone at the edge, not competing with others for space. With one hand in her pocket and the other playing a mobile game, she casually tapped the screen a few times.

Xu Qingzhu glanced at her across the crowd, then withdrew her gaze.

It was just a simple look, but Zhou Yi'an noticed her too.

However, the two didn't greet each other.

Sally happened to walk over and patted Xu Qingzhu's shoulder. "Blanche, didn't you go to eat with Zhou Yi'an? Why did you come back separately? Did you fight?"

Xu Qingzhu shook her head: "No."

"Alright then." Sally glanced at Zhou Yi'an standing there all alone. "Anyone who could get into a fight with Zhou Yi'an would be quite capable."

Xu Qingzhu: "Hm?"

"Zhou Yi'an is probably the type who would resort to physical action rather than verbal arguments." Sally said.

Xu Qingzhu smiled perfunctorily and didn't continue the topic.

Sally had only been making small talk with her anyway. In the crowded elevator, no one spoke again.

All the way back to her office, Xu Qingzhu placed the coffee on her desk, took out her phone again, then opened her conversation with Zhou Yi'an. That sentence: [A person who has lived in a psychiatric hospital for years—do you think she's doing well?]

Living in a psychiatric hospital for years...

Xu Qingzhu wanted to ask something, but didn't know where to begin.

And she had no motivation to ask.

She sat there thinking—why should she ask?

What use would it be after asking?

What answer did she want to obtain?

Reason forced her back to her original position. After a long while, she replied to Zhou Yi'an: [Truly a case of heaven envying the talented.]

Just like her poor uncle¹.

Geniuses are like shooting stars—they fall at their most brilliant moment.

Zhou Yi'an quickly replied: [?]

As if she hadn't expected her to respond from an outsider's perspective.

And facing this question mark, Xu Qingzhu's reply was: [Let's get to work.]

Zhou Yi'an: [...]

Indeed, very calm.

Calm to the point of being almost cold.

Zhou Yi'an stared at those two replies on the screen, her brows tightly furrowed. She couldn't help but reply: [President Xu must take after her father more.]

Xu Qingzhu: [...What makes you say that?]

Zhou Yi'an: [Those who understand will understand.]

Xu Qingzhu: [Then I don't understand.]

Zhou Yi'an was struggling with whether or not to explain when Xu Qingzhu sent a long message.

[I don't have much time to play guessing games with you. If you want to tell me some groundless rumors, I don't particularly want to hear them. Who I inherited traits from isn't important—what matters is that I've already grown into who I am now. Designer Zhou, it's better for you to interfere less in other people's family affairs. If you have free and ample time, why not think more about our theme proposal for next quarter.]

Zhou Yi'an: [...]

She put down her phone and looked across to Xu Qingzhu's office. The instant their eyes met, Xu Qingzhu closed the venetian blinds² of her office.

Zhou Yi'an suddenly smiled.

Lin Luoxi passed by Zhou Yi'an's workstation and went to Xu Qingzhu's office, placing the documents she had just picked up on her desk. Curiously, she asked: "Why did you suddenly go eat with Zhou Yi'an?"

Xu Qingzhu flipped through the documents while answering: "We discussed something."

"You two didn't fight, did you?" Lin Luoxi asked.

Xu Qingzhu shook her head: "No, why?"

Lin Luoxi paused, then shook her head on her own. "As long as you didn't fight. When I just walked past her workstation, I saw her staring at your office and smiling."

Xu Qingzhu: "Huh?"

Lin Luoxi shook her head, trying to drive Zhou Yi'an's smile from her mind, but found it futile.

That person was beautiful, but her smile was rather sinister.

Once you've seen it, it's hard to forget.

Lin Luoxi could only say: "Anyway, be careful. Her smile was... strangely perverted."

Xu Qingzhu: "...Oh."

Footnotes:

¹ Uncle (舅舅, jiùjiu): Refers to Xu Qingzhu's maternal uncle, who was previously mentioned in the story as someone with exceptional talent who died young.

² Venetian blinds (百葉窗, bǎiyèchuāng): Window blinds with horizontal slats that can be adjusted to control light and privacy.